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A Critical Analysis of Borges's "Library of Babel"

Jorge Borges's *Library of Babel* discusses a fictional library in which every possible combination of the twenty-five orthographic symbols is contained in an unimaginably large, but finite, collection of books. As such, the library contains everything that has been said and which could be said in the future, but most of the books are incomprehensible nonsense with strings of random symbols. In his essay, Borges considers the detrimental effects of such a place, where greed to acquire the knowledge contained in the library led to a significant portion of it being destroyed, and conflict among those scouring its corridors for anything that could assist them in even the most minute ways. This brings about the question of the true value of information, and what can and should be sacrificed in order to gain it, a question this speech will explore through connections to Borges's story and relevant modern examples.

One of the main ideas Borges explores is the concept of infinity and its implications. Since the library contains all possible combinations of the twenty-five symbols, it is technically not infinite, though the number of books and thus size of the library are so large that it could be perceived as infinite. This results in a paradox of sorts - the library is finite, though unbounded. The idea connects back to the beginning of Borges's story, in which he uses the words "library" and "universe" interchangeably. In his story, the universe is the library, and vice versa. From this point, one might see that searching the library for information is a metaphor for our desire to understand the real world.

This leads into the next theme, which is the overwhelming lack of information resulting in significant desire to find it. An issue arises, though, since the probability of finding any information with real utility in the library is negligible. Using the metaphor previously established, it can be argued that finding any such information is a near-impossibility even in the real world. So much that is useful or important is bogged down by unnecessary or incorrect details, and even by biased opinions. As such, the *Library of Babel* is a metaphor for the futility of the human species to acquire what is perceived to be an infinite amount of knowledge. There are simply too many details, too many stipulations and possibilities, and too much useless information to sift through to be able to understand everything. The perceived infiniteness of the library and of our universe prompts a multitude of questions whose answers are virtually impossible to obtain.

With the aforementioned analysis, one might ask several questions. What do we perceive to be important? A piece of information which seems useless now could be helpful later on, that perception could be based on our current lack of knowledge. In the context of the library, a book which appears to be complete nonsense could have some hidden meaning which may not be

ascertainable given our prior knowledge. Perhaps it can be revisited at a later date and understood, or perhaps it is truly worthless. This initial perception of uselessness can lead to significant problems though, as the chance of revisiting the book becomes negligible. One might recall the fact that much of the Library of Babel was burned as soon as the content was perceived as gibberish, eliminating any possibility of understanding it in the future.

It can also be asked why we should continue to seek out knowledge if it is so challenging to find. Why should we expend so much energy and so many resources if the chance of finding anything even remotely beneficial is so low? One might think that there will always be value in gaining knowledge, and that it should be sought after at all costs. Others may have a more conservative approach toward the matter, not wanting to risk what they already have for something they may not get. This leads directly to the last of the three major questions - the question of the true value of knowledge. This is probably the most difficult to answer, since there is no concrete answer and its implications will vary between all people. Some knowledge might be extremely useful to some but entirely pointless to others. A shoe salesman must be familiar with the precise differences between a neutral and a stability shoe, but have no need for the advanced metaphysical knowledge possessed by the worlds' top scientists. However, can it really be said that any knowledge is completely useless? Surely it would depend upon the person's ideology and life outlook, as some are more intrigued by a wide range of topics while others are content with understanding the basics. This is to say that the questions conjured up by Borges' story are likely to be unanswerable so long as uncertainty and the greyness of the universe persist.

The themes established in Borges' works are further complicated by other issues. It was mentioned that much of the information we are provided or that we find is effectively useless or even biased. This is seen in the real world on a daily basis, where the validity and importance of what is being taught in schools across the United States is constantly called into question. Many students will not have to be familiar with the functions of the mitochondria, but may have received teaching on such topics instead of topics more applicable to their future careers and themselves personally. It is also seen in the news, one might cite the fake news revolution that has occurred in recent years. It has become increasingly difficult to know the truth on matters, especially those relating to politics as the United States appears to become increasingly divided. This partition is only heightened as both sides of the argument attempt to sway people to their perspective, often ignoring the morality and correctness of the information they decide to use.

The questions explored in this speech will continue to pervade our existence through eternity, and their answers will continue to elude us due to our ever-changing understanding of ourselves, of each other, and of the universe. That said, Borges' explores an interesting idea toward the end of his essay. The narrator posits that since the library contains all possible combinations of characters, there must exist books which explain the books that seem to be complete nonsense. Thus, everything which does not appear to have meaning can be given meaning by something else. This idea can be extrapolated to say that there is no problem whose solution simply does not exist, as there must be some amount of information missing which

would reveal the answer. In this way, there is hope that our desire to understand the universe is not futile, and should be fueled at all costs. One might even say that it is within our very nature, our DNA, to continue our quest for knowledge. Perhaps it is our purpose.

Source Text:

Borges, Jorge L. "The Library of Babel" from "The Garden of Forking Paths". *Editorial Sur*, 1941. Published in English 1948.

<https://sites.evergreen.edu/politicalshakespeares/wp-content/uploads/sites/226/2015/12/Borges-The-Library-of-Babel.pdf>

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